

South China Sea

KEY INSIGHT_

“What ordinary people don't know is already shaping their lives.”

PROBLEM_

What ordinary people don't know is already shaping their lives.

A large-scale mixed media installation exploring the South China Sea conflict through the lens of public naivety. Presented as a detective board, it connects geopolitics to lived experience through cyanotypes, photograms, coffee-aged maps, and original photography.

MY ROLE_

Sole artist across concept, research, photography, darkroom work, and installation.

SOLUTION_

A detective board that makes viewers discover the conflict instead of being told it.

The final installation combined original photography, cyanotypes, photograms, coffee-aged map prints, handwritten notes, and red string into a seven-foot visual system.



Close to home, under-discussed, and layered in tension.

Starting from the wars in Gaza and Ukraine, I narrowed the project to the South China Sea conflict, a crisis close to home but often absent from ordinary public conversation.

RESEARCH_

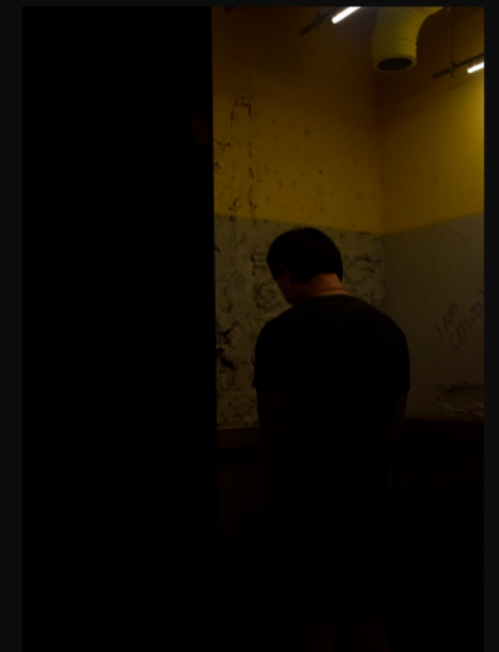
The public knows fragments, not the full system.

Research focused on how economic, territorial, and military pressures overlap, and how little of that complexity enters everyday understanding.

CHALLENGE_

The work needed a structure that felt investigative, not decorative.

A detective board became the central metaphor: red threads, mapped clues, and layered evidence mirroring how the public tries, and often fails, to connect the dots.



Physical processes made the conflict feel discovered rather than explained.

Cyanotypes introduced blue as a material link to the sea. Coffee aging gave archival maps a worn authority. Photograms stripped figures of context and identity, while the detective-board structure held the research together.



The detective board let viewers uncover relationships rather than receive a lecture.



OUTCOME_

The detective board was the right call. The piece lived in visual discovery.

What worked best was making the audience trace relationships for themselves. If revisited, the next step would be adding a stronger sound or ambient layer so the work reaches beyond the visual.

OUTCOME_

The board made viewers discover connections rather than be told them.

That active reading process became central to the installation's effect and made the conflict feel less distant.

NEXT_

The next version should add sound and bodily atmosphere.

The visual system carried the project. A stronger ambient or sonic layer would make the tension more immersive.

